
Susan Collins' time is up as Maine's Houdini

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Susan Collins' time is up as Maine's Houdini

Susan Collins is very concerned — and she should be. As a politician who has only run for one office in her life and held the same seat for nearly 30 years, the Maine senator is facing a possible loss in what looks more and more like a [big blue wave](#) coming in November's midterm elections. As the rare GOP senator representing a blue state, she should be the first one caught in that undertow. But Collins is a rare creature: a virtual Houdini who has always managed to fend off defeat during tough elections. Whether she will somehow work her magic again is one of the biggest questions of 2026.

At the start of this election cycle, Democrats had two competing strategies about how to beat her. Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer was convinced that because more women than men vote in the state and Collins wins most of them, the answer was to find a Democratic woman that closely matched Collins' profile. So he persuaded the popular Democratic Gov. Janet Mills, 79, to run for the seat. A progressive faction took the opposite approach, believing that a younger, male populist outsider would provide the contrast Mainers were looking for. So they recruited a lobster fisherman, Graham Platner. It soon became clear that Schumer's bet was the wrong one, and that Platner's persona and message were more appealing. Mills' heart wasn't really in the race, and she dropped out fairly quickly. But then, after Platner was [forced to withdraw](#) from the race due to credible allegations of sexual assault, he was replaced with another salt-of-the-earth working man type. Troy Jackson, a fifth-generation logger who once served as president of the Main Senate, was well-known in the state and became something of a compromise candidate. Collins is currently trailing Jackson in most polls, although the revered [New York Times/Portland Press/Siena poll](#), released Thursday, showed her with a small lead.

While no one is counting their chickens, the environment appears to favor Democrats. This is the first election for Collins since the Supreme Court's Dobbs ruling, which overturned Roe v. Wade and decades of access to abortion. Since the senator had effectively [cast the deciding vote](#) to confirm Brett Kavanaugh to the Supreme Court in 2018, vouching for his mainstream credentials and assuring Americans he considered Roe "settled law," the case also severely damaged her reputation as a moderate among many Maine voters, most of whom — remember — are women. Collins has since claimed she was "misled" by Kavanaugh, but she has [refused to repudiate her vote](#).

What had once been one of the senator's selling points — her position on choice — is now a liability. But it doesn't stop there. According to [analysis](#) by Planned Parenthood, Collins has subsequently supported 95% of Trump's judicial nominees — to be fair, that percentage is roughly [on par with her votes](#) in previous administrations — including for anti-choice judges. She has also voted against the Equality Act, which would add sexual orientation and gender identity to civil rights laws, legislation she had [previously co-sponsored](#). For some voters who backed her before, this is a deal breaker.

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Collins' other selling point to Mainers of all political stripes has been her dedication to bringing home pork for the state as the chair of the powerful Appropriations Committee. While that power has been somewhat curtailed by both parties in recent years after revelations of such schemes as former GOP Alaska Sen. Ted Stevens' infamous "[bridge to nowhere](#)," Collins has managed to keep the tradition going, albeit with a more subtle application.

Throughout the campaign, Jackson has portrayed Collins as a tool of the corrupt GOP swamp, tying her to Trump and the party's overwhelming corruption. While it's hard to know how much traction Jackson has been getting on that issue, last week he was handed a gift in the form of a [Pro Publica story](#) alleging that Collins engaged in suspicious pay-to-play arrangements via a high-powered Washington lobbyist who is close to her and her husband. (Reporting by the New York Times [supported](#) the claim.)

In a nutshell, the former CEO of a defense contractor told the FBI that he created a shell company to hide a \$150,000 donation to a super PAC supporting Collins in exchange for her help in obtaining millions in contracts, which he received. There is evidence that she not only knew about it, but worked with others to make it happen. After a preliminary FBI investigation in 2023 didn't lead to any charges, new evidence was apparently leading the bureau to a larger investigation when the Trump Justice Department quashed it as part of their purge of the agents and lawyers who were working political corruption cases.

Collins maintains she was cleared of any wrongdoing, but there is a big cloud over her head at the exact moment voters are increasingly concerned about government corruption writ large. It doesn't help that she has enabled Trump and his administration all along the way. She might vote with him less than other Republican senators, but that's not saying much, since many of them are barely sentient rubber stamps. And Collins certainly hasn't been a crusader against his unconstitutional usurpation of Congress' power of the purse, which is only going to get worse now that the president is entering his lame duck period. Among her confirmation votes was one in favor of budget director Russell Vought, the main author of Project 2025, who continues to make the case that Trump has the power and right to cancel congressional appropriations he doesn't like.

Collins' big pitch to the people of Maine is her perennial favorite — that she has seniority and power, and that she will use it for their benefit. But she has shown little appetite for using any of it to stop the worst consequences for Maine and the country-at-large. In the end, it may come down to whether Mainers care more about Collins' record of bringing home the bacon or about saving the country from a malignant administration.

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